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MASORETIC STUDIES 6

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CONJUNCTIVE *DAGESH*: A PRELIMINARY STUDY

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The term "Conjunctive Dagesh" is used here to cover both the phenomena traditionally referred to as *dehiq*, and those referred to as *ʔatē merahiq*.¹ The descriptions of these phenomena in the standard grammars, such as those of Gesenius-Kautzsch, Bergsträsser, or Joüon, are based on that of S. Baer. Baer sees the phenomenon as following set rules, with very few exceptions. Even in the limited range of examples which he gives, however, there are many variants from the Leningrad Codex B19a (L). The description given by I. Yeivin is less inclined to see the phenomenon as following fixed rules, and admits a considerable number of exceptions in some situations. This description is less complex than is Baer's, having merged some of the categories set up by Baer. However its use of the masoretic definition of vocal *shewa*, and its treatment of the use of *maqgef* separately from the use of a conjunctive accent seems to complicate the description unnecessarily.²

Conjunctive *dagesh* typically occurs where a word ending in an unstressed open syllable with the vowel *qameṣ* or *segol* (terminal, or followed by *he*), and marked with a conjunctive accent or *maqgef*, is followed by a word stressed on its first full vowel

1. I had originally intended to use the term *dehiq* to cover both (following the suggestion of Dotan "The Problem of *Dehiq* and *Atē Merahiq*" *Fourth World Congress of Jewish Studies, Papers*, Vol. II [Jerusalem, 1969]: 101-105 [Hebrew], 186 [English summary] about its original meaning), but since most descriptions use both terms in the traditional way, this seems unwise.

2. For Baer's description see "De primarum vocabulorum literarum dagessatione" (in his *Liber Proverbiorum*, Lipsiae, 1880: vii-xiii). For that of Yeivin, see his *Introduction to the Tiberian Masorah*, Missoula, 1980, #404-405. Yeivin's description is based on A.

(i.e. C'V-- or CəC'V--, etc.). A pair of words with these characteristics is referred to here as a "standard pair". Where such a pair occurs, *dagesh* may be marked in the first letter of the second word. This "conjunctive *dagesh*" is never used in initial *alef*, *he*, *het*, *ayin*, or *waw*, so cases in which the second word begins with one of these letters are not considered as examples of a "standard pair". In L, conjunctive *dagesh* is not used after a word ending in *alef* in the Hebrew text (as far as I know -- including **אֶל-תָּרָא יִינִי** in Prov 23:31, mentioned in Yeivin's #404), but is used several times in the Aramaic parts of Daniel and Ezra (which are not extant in A), as **כִּלְא מִסָּא** (Dan 4:25), **אֶמְרֵנָא לְהֵם** (Ezra 5:4, 9). These Aramaic examples are not considered here. The special case of **מִה** is also ignored. Apart from these, I have noted only 28 cases (less than 1/3 of 1%) in which conjunctive *dagesh* is used in a situation different from that of the standard pair defined above.³

It appears from a survey of the standard pairs collected that, when other conditions are the same, it makes no difference to the use of conjunctive *dagesh* whether the two words are joined by a conjunctive accent or by *maqfef*. Consequently the two situations are not distinguished. It also appears that *shewa* is most usefully classified according to whether it does or does not reflect an earlier vowel. When the material is treated in this way, the basic pattern of occurrence of conjunctive *dagesh* can be described very simply. Conjunctive *dagesh* typically occurs in three categories of standard pairs:

1. Where the first word ends in *segol*. 231 of 242 cases (95%), as Gen 2:18 **אֶתְשֶׁה-לָּךְ**.
2. Where the first word ends in *qameṣ*, if that *qameṣ* is typically not stressed in the contextual form of that word. 304 of 330 cases (92%), as Gen 12:18 **הִנְדִּיתִי-לִי**.
3. Where the first word ends in *qameṣ* preceded by a *shewa* which is marked as vocal, or reflects an earlier vowel. 153 of 178 cases (86%) as Gen 18:21 **אֲבִרְהָ-נָא**.

In category 3, the final *qameṣ* is typically stressed in the contextual form. In a fourth category, the other cases in which the first word of a standard pair ends in *qameṣ* which is typically stressed in the contextual form, conjunctive *dagesh* typically does not occur. 170 of 184 cases (92%), as Gen 4:6 **תָּרָא לָךְ**.

3. Conjunctive *dagesh* occurs in a few cases in which the first word of the pair has final stress (Yeivin, op. cit. #405, end) and (more commonly) where the second word is not stressed on its first syllable (ibid. #407.i, see also #4 below). The presence or absence of *ga ya* is of no significance in L in the latter cases (see ibid. #406).

The list of examples of conjunctive *dagesh* from which these figures are taken was generated by computer search of the FCAT text of the Bible in transliteration. The problems of using this text for a search of this sort were not fully solved; a hand search revealed about 10% more examples. This hand search has been carried out over Genesis, and the text extant in A. Consequently the list of examples used in this preliminary study is not complete, but should be nearly so. The material was studied in L, and the usage of L in the examples collected was compared with A and C.⁴ These codices rarely differ from L save in a few cases where they use conjunctive *dagesh* according to the standard pattern, but L fails to use it. Some of these cases are noted below. In one case, however, all three sources differ. In **וְרָאָה שְׁמֹה** (2 Kgs 9:2), A has *ga'ya* and *maqfēf* on the verb, and shows conjunctive *dagesh*. L has *tifha* and does not show *dagesh*. Both, then, are consistent with the standard pattern. C also shows *tifha* on the verb, and shows *dagesh* in the first letter of the following word. This *dagesh* is anomalous (since the first word of the pair has a disjunctive) looks like the result of conflation. There are a few other cases in which it seems possible that the use of conjunctive *dagesh* developed in a form of the tradition slightly different from that shown in these codices. Among the most persuasive are:

Jud 6:39	אֲנִי־נָא־כֹּה־נִפְעָם
Ps 118:25	הוֹשִׁיעָה נָא . . . הַצִּלֵּיתָהּ נָא

The figures for the standard categories given above show that the use of conjunctive *dagesh* is much more regular than is generally supposed. This impression is strengthened by a consideration of the exceptions. Many of these fall into groups which can be defined morphologically, and undoubtedly reflect inaccuracy in the description rather than irregularity in the phenomenon. Thus the fourteen exceptions in category 4 are all 2m.s perfect forms with *waw* consecutive, as Deut 27:7

4. Facsimiles of these sources are published as follows: L as *Pentateuch, Prophets, and Hagiographa: Codex Leningrad B19a* with an introduction by D. S. Loewinger, Jerusalem, 1970; A as *The Aleppo Codex* ed. by M. H. Goshen Gottstein, Jerusalem, 1976; C as *The Cairo Codex of the Prophets* ed. by D. S. Loewinger, Jerusalem, 1971. P, *Prophetarum posteriorum codex babylonicus Petropolitanus* ed. H. Strack, St. Petersburg, 1881, was also compared, as was *The Old Testament ... with the Various Readings from the MSS* (ed. by C. D. Ginsburg, London, 1926). Some of the variations from L shown by P may be systematic, but neither these, nor those recorded by Ginsburg (which do not appear to be systematic) are significant for the present purpose.

שָׁם וְזָכַרְתָּ שְׁלֵמִים וְאַכְלֶתָ שָׁם.⁵ That is, in the matter of conjunctive *dagesh*, the perfect with *waw* consecutive acts like a "simple" perfect, a member of category 2.

The question of whether a word ending in *qames* typically has final or penultimate stress in contextual position is not always clear. Apart from 2m.s forms of perfect with *waw* consecutive, however, it is always possible to give a plausible answer consistent with the pattern shown in the standard categories. As far as I know, the only case where such an answer differs from the commonly accepted view of the form is that of מְכַהֵל־לָּהּ (2 Kgs 4:27). The first word of the pair is usually categorized as a perfect verb form.⁶ In this case stress would be typically penultimate and *dagesh* is expected. The form could equally well be an adjective. In this case typical stress would be final, and the lack of conjunctive *dagesh* in the following לָּהּ would conform to the expected pattern. Typical final stress is also assumed for שְׁמֵרָה (Amos 1:11. The final *he* represents a pronoun), and (with less certainty) אֲוִירָה (Ps 120:5). Unusual forms for which typical penultimate stress is assumed are הִכָּה (Gen 30:1, etc.);⁷ כָּנָה (2 Sam 24:6, the final *he* is "directional"); and וְהִגִּיתָה (Zech 5:11, with stress position corresponding to that of the *hif'il*). Typical penultimate stress for the noun forms like יְשׁוּעָה (Ps 3:3), צִוְיָה (Ps 44:27), עֲרֵלָה (Ps 92:16), כְּצִרְתָּה (Ps 120:1) is amply demonstrated in nouns of this form elsewhere (Exod 15:16, Ezek 28:15, Jonah 2:10, etc.). It can reasonably be stated, then, that in category 4, where the first word of a standard pair ends in *qames* which is typically stressed in context and is not preceded by *shewa* reflecting an earlier vowel, the failure to use conjunctive *dagesh* is absolutely regular.

Where the first word of a standard pair ends in *qames* which is typically not stressed in context, the largest group of exceptions to the common pattern (I have 13 examples) occurs where the second word of the pair has a prefixed preposition (וְ- or

5. Exod 25:12, Lev 25:35, Deut 14:26, 16:2, 17:14, 26:1, 27:7, 28:36, 64, 2 Sam 9:10, 1 Kgs 22:13, Ezek 28:12, 35:3, 2 Chron 18:12. These are all from strong roots. *Waw* consecutive perfect forms from final weak roots do not usually develop final stress.

6. So, e.g., the Lexicon of Brown, Driver and Briggs, also that of Koehler, Baumgartner, et. al., also A. Even-Shoshan, *A New Concordance of the Bible* (Jerusalem, 1982).

7. This would be irregular of the root is יָהַב, but the imperative of נָגַשׁ shows similar forms with penultimate stress beside the expected patterns. Identical forms of imperative (of different origin) occur in אָנָה (Num 22:6), and קָנָה (Num 22:11).

-ל -- a well-known phenomenon, although not so consistent as is sometimes suggested).

In the second largest group of exceptions in category 2, the first word is a feminine plural imperfect form from a final weak root with *segol* as its penultimate stressed vowel. I have noted six examples, as נִקְהַיְנָה לִי (Ezek 23:4).⁸ C agrees with L in not showing conjunctive *dagesh* here, as does A in all six cases. It is difficult to see how these exceptions could have a phonological basis. Conjunctive *dagesh* does occur after a word ending in stressed *segol* followed by *qameṣ* where the two vowels are separated by *nun* marked with *dagesh*, as with the suffixes in 1 Sam 18:21, 21:10, etc., and even in Mic 7:10 תִּרְאִינָה כֶּה. It also occurs where vowels are separated by a single consonant other than *nun* as in Gen 14:10, 38:29, Jos 8:28, etc. It is remarkable, however, that f.pl imperfect verbs commonly form exceptions to other standard phonological patterns. Neither the change of original *a to *qameṣ* in pause, nor the change of original *i to *pataḥ* in a closed stressed syllable, occurs regularly in these forms.⁹ What connection, if any, this has with the development of conjunctive *dagesh* is a matter for speculation.

In a number of other other exceptions to the standard pattern in category 2, conjunctive *dagesh* does not occur in L where A and C do show it. Most of these reflect the tendency in L, noted by Prof. Dotan, to omit *dagesh* in initial *ṣ*, *ḡ*, etc., where the second letter of the word has *dagesh*.¹⁰ Of the other cases of omission of expected *dagesh*, in L at least, שָׁמַע וּבָאֲזַיֵּךְ (Ezek 3:10) appears to be an error. L does show *dagesh* in the same pair in Ezek 40:4, 44:5; A and C show it in all three cases. In fact, there are only two cases in L in category 2 which do not appear clearly

8. Also forms from קרא in Ruth 1:20, 20, 21, 4:17, 17. Conjunctive *dagesh* occurs regularly in f.pl imperfect forms where the penultimate syllable is closed, as חִלְכְּנָה מִיָּם (Ezek 7:17), and also where that syllable is open with *holem* in לָרָה נִתְבְּאֲנָה in L, (Isa 47:9) A, C.

9. *Pataḥ* reflects original *a in the stressed syllable of an f.pl imperfect form in pause in Isa 5:15, 32:3, 60:14, Jer 49:2, Mic 7:16, and even before **ayin* in חִשְׁבְּעָנָה (Prov. 27:20, 20, 30:15). As far as I know, *qameṣ* occurs only in חִישְׁמָנָה (Ezek 6:6). *Ṣere* occurs regularly in the stressed syllable of f.pl imperfect forms from *pi^el* or *hifⁱl* stems, and in the *qal* form תִּגְלָנָה (Ps 48:12, 51:10, 97:8). The expected *pataḥ* occurs in other *qal* forms, as חִלְכְּנָה, and in *nifⁱl* forms.

10. See A. Dotan, "Deviation in Gemination in the Tiberian Vocalization", *Estudios Masoreticos*, ed. E. Fernández-Tejero (Textos y Estudios vol. 33, 1983):67.

to result from conditioning (phonological or otherwise) or error, and even these may be explicable.

Neither the few exceptions in category 1, nor the many in category 3, show such clear evidence of conditioning, but it seems probable that some, at least, were conditioned. In category 1, where a standard pair is formed of אֵלָה followed by a preposition with a pronominal suffix, as מֵה־אֵלָה לָרִ (2 Sam 16:2, and similarly Gen 33:5, 38:25, Ezek 24:19, 39:18), conjunctive *dagesh* is used. Where the second word is a noun or adverb, as וְאֵלָה שְׁמוֹת בְּנֵי־לְוִי (Exod 6:16, and similarly Gen 46:8, Deut 5:3, Isa 47:9), conjunctive *dagesh* is not used. It seems likely that in this latter group the prosodic patterns defining the structures originally prevented the development of conjunctive *dagesh*. That is to say, they were different from those reflected by the received accentuation. It is noteworthy that, in the 17 other cases where שְׁמוֹת אֵלָה is followed by a noun or noun phrase, אֵלָה has a disjunctive accent, and so cannot form a standard pair. In category 3, nouns in which the penultimate syllable was originally closed by a guttural which is followed by a *hatef shewa* in L act in the same way as do nouns in which a simple *shewa* in the same position is considered silent, as בְּחֵלֶה־לְנוֹ (2 Sam 20:1, other forms Ezek 28:17, Prov 13:12, 15:17), compare וְעֵנְה־צֶרֶק (Ps 45:5, other forms Mic 1:11, Ps 45:5, Prov 17:1). Despite the vocal *shewa* before the final *qames*, forms like בְּחֵלֶה act as members of category 4.

Other forms with *shewa* before a final *qames* also raise problems. Cases where the first word in a standard pair is a feminine form noun acting as an infinitive, as לְטַמְאֵה־הָ (Lev 15:32, 18:20, 23, 22:8), וּלְכַבֶּה־כּוֹ (Deut 11:22, 30:20, Jos 22:5) appear to have a closed penultimate syllable and typical final stress, like עֲנֵה etc. They thus belong to category 4, so that conjunctive *dagesh* is not expected. However conjunctive *dagesh* is regularly used after imperative forms of apparently similar structure, as וְכַבֶּה־לִּי (Neh 5:19, similarly Neh 13:14, 22, 1 Chron 29:18) and שְׁמַע־לִי (Job 32:10, similarly Job 34:16). Conjunctive *dagesh* is also used after two other forms in which the penultimate syllable would generally be considered closed: נַעֲמַד־הֶחָדָר (Isa 50:8) and נַעֲזְבֵה־נָא (Neh 5:10). A vowel clearly was used between the last two root consonants of such forms in some traditions.¹¹ It is possible that the presence or absence of such a vowel was the factor which conditioned the use or non-

11. As is shown by the use of Waw before the last root consonant in imperative forms, as קְלוּכָה in Jud 9:8, and in נַעֲמֹרָה (Isa 50:8) in 1QIsa^a. Cf. also יַעֲמֹרָה In Cambridge University Library MS TS 16:96 (=P. E. Kahle, *MdW II*, MS J) Dan 11:14 (יַעֲמֹרָה).

use of conjunctive *dagesh*. It is also possible that the conditioning factor was some other feature in which verbs characteristically differed from nouns.

Third person feminine singular perfect verb forms provide another case in which the status of *shewa* is uncertain. Such forms are followed by conjunctive *dagesh* in 74 cases, (excluding forms which are, or may be, f.s participles), as קָפְצָה פִּירָה (Ps 107:42, Job 5:16). In another six cases, *dagesh* does not occur, as וַמְחַמֵּה פִּירָה (Prov 30:20). As the examples indicate, there is no obvious reason for the 7% of exceptions. The *shewa* in such forms is quite often written as composite (as in Prov 30:20), and was unquestionably vocal at one time. In the present context, these forms would belong in category 4 if the *shewa* were silent. In this case conjunctive *dagesh* in the following word would be exceptional. In fact, however, the only forms in which a final *qames* which is typically stressed is preceded by a silent *shewa* are the noun and infinitive forms described above. Thus there is a possibility that the factor that governs the use of conjunctive *dagesh* is not the vocal or silent nature of the *shewa*, but some characteristic difference between verbs and nouns. The most obvious difference is the fact that, in nouns, stress on a final *qames* is not the result of a shift of stress from penultimate position, while in verb forms, it is.

If this difference is the conditioning factor, the description of conjunctive *dagesh* in words ending in *qames* can be simplified. Categories 2-3-4 can be replaced by the statement that conjunctive *dagesh* occurs after words in which the final *qames* was not originally stressed, not after those in which it was. Under this formulation, *waw* consecutive perfect forms are no longer exceptional, and there is no irregularity in the use of conjunctive *dagesh* after the superficially identical infinitive and imperative forms discussed above. The same applies to its use after סָאָה in the three cases of סָאָה-סָלַח (2 Kgs 7:1, 16, 18) in which the absence of conjunctive *dagesh* contrasts with its regular presence after imperative forms of the same structure, as in שָׁכַח-פָּהוּ (Rut 4:1 and 20 other cases). Exceptions to the standard pattern remain, of course, but under this simpler description the largest proportion is 8% in any category. Some of these 8% represent errors by the *naqdan* of L; others are phonologically conditioned. The remaining proportion of anomalies is small enough that it can be confidently stated that the phenomenon represented by conjunctive *dagesh* results automatically from close juncture in the situation described as a standard pair. It is not a Masoretic mystery, but a *sandhi* phenomenon. It is to be hoped that further study of a complete collection of cases of conjunctive *dagesh* will show that error or particular phonological conditioning accounts for the majority of anomalies, and so place this conclusion beyond the possibility of doubt.